



Spray treatment: The race at Spa-Francorchamps began in classic fashion — a rain delay, five Safety Car laps, and a rolling start on Lap 6. REUTERS

Learning curve

Bouncing back from a disappointing result in the 100-lap shootout, Piastri was not at his usual best during qualifying. A rare inaccuracy by Piastri allowed Norris to grab pole, but a window of opportunity was now wide open.

Sunday began in classic Spa fashion — a rain delay, five Safety Car laps, and a rolling start on Lap 6. As the field cautiously peeled away, Piastri pounced, and quite bravely at that. He proved he can be a quick learner, mimicking Verstappen's overtake to perfection. Norris could only watch as his rival drifted away into the spray.

The rain stayed away thereon, and the track dried up soon enough. The one who triggered a wave of pit stops was Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton, whose revival drive powered his pit-stop-to-points finish. The tyre change was the right call — McLaren brought Piastri in first for mediums, and Norris a lap later for hards, betting on long-term gain.

Norris lost time with a slower pit stop but stayed close, managing his tyres and waiting for Piastri to pit again. But the medium tyres lasted longer than expected, and suddenly, the advantage was back with Piastri.

It became clear that McLaren's tyre split strategy would shape the final

act of the race. Norris had to push, but Piastri had the track position and enough grip to defend it.

Right on time

By Lap 39, Norris had slashed the gap to under three seconds. Overtaking a teammate with equal machinery and high stakes is rarely straightforward. He had gotten all too familiar with playing catch-up, but might have left too much to do towards the end once again.

With two laps to go, Norris made a mistake, undoing the painstaking charge and sealing his fate. Piastri crossed the line over three seconds ahead to clinch his eighth career victory and extend his lead to 16 points. He reasserted himself in what is becoming the most compelling intra-team rivalry of the year.

Behind the battling McLarens, Ferrari's Charles Leclerc quietly executed one of his most assured drives of the season to take the final podium place. Yet another perfect qualifying lap helped him oust sprint winner Verstappen, who couldn't find a way past the Ferrari driver in the 44-lap event.

But when the top two crossed the line, Leclerc was nowhere near. The gap? Almost 20 seconds. The sight of the McLarens thriving up front is all too common by now, but what is becoming increasingly difficult to predict is how close the fight keeps getting.

Each weekend seems to tilt the scale in a different direction — and at Spa, it swayed back towards Piastri.



REUTERS

MotoGP



Marc Marquez has been the embodiment of pushing the limit this season.

Back-to-back race weekends saw Marquez emerge victorious in Germany and Czechia, en route to becoming the first Ducati rider to win five consecutive MotoGP races.

The Spaniard secured his ninth victory at Sachsenring, an event that was marked by multiple crashes, with only 10 out of 18 riders finishing. He staged a lights-to-flag victory while his brother, Alex Marquez, finished second despite a fractured hand, and Francesco Bagnaia came home third.

A week later at the Dutch TT in Assen, Marquez was off to a rough start. He recovered from two crashes in practice and overcame a poor qualifying to charge through the field. He finished clear of Aprilia's Marco Bezzecchi and his Ducati teammate Bagnaia, who was denied a fourth straight win here.

With a 120-point gap and 10 rounds remaining, catching Marquez will be next to impossible.